The Jungle

Upton Sinclair · 1906 · excerpts from Chapter 9 / Chapter 14

Source: Project Gutenberg, gutenberg.org/ebooks/140.

Upton Sinclair spent seven weeks undercover in the Chicago meatpacking plants in 1904 and produced this novel about Lithuanian immigrant Jurgis Rudkus. Sinclair intended the book as socialist propaganda — an exposé of industrial labor. What captured the public instead were the descriptions of unsanitary meat production. Within months of publication, Congress passed the Pure Food and Drug Act and the Meat Inspection Act (both 1906). Sinclair famously said: 'I aimed at the public's heart, and by accident I hit it in the stomach.'

Connect: Sinclair wanted to expose worker abuse but changed food-safety law instead. What does that reveal about Progressive-era priorities compared with Gilded Age labor movements (Class 30)?

Key Passages

On 'potted ham'

> It was only when the whole ham was spoiled that it came into the department of Elzbieta. Cut up by the two-thousand-revolutions-a-minute flyers, and mixed with half a ton of other meat, no odor that ever was in a ham could make any difference.

On the lard tanks

> Sometimes they would be overlooked for days, till all but the bones of them had gone out to the world as Durham's Pure Leaf Lard!

On the workforce

> There were men in the pickle rooms … their hands would be criss-crossed with cuts, until you could no longer pretend to count them or to trace them. They would have no nails — they had worn them off pulling hides.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — explain similarities OR differences: Compare The Jungle's impact with that of Uncle Tom's Cabin a half-century earlier.

2. Why did the public focus on meat safety rather than worker safety? What does that tell you about Progressive-era priorities?

3. Identify ONE specific federal law passed within a year of publication.